

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: A multitrack transition, not one date

c. 300-550 -> Gupta-Vakataka repertoires and widening land-grant practice
c. 550-750 -> post-Gupta polities, samantas and stronger regional houses
c. 750-1200 -> temple institutions, regional states and vernacular cultures
POLITICS -> AGRARIAN ORDER -> SOCIETY -> RELIGION -> LANGUAGE
Each track changes at a different speed and in a different region.
RULE: 1206 is not the single birth date of medieval India.

ASCHII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: Continuity, change and regional variation

CONTINUITY -> Sanskrit prestige, inherited law, pilgrimage and sacred centres

CHANGE -> distributed sovereignty, denser grants and temple-centred institutions

REGIONAL VARIATION -> Bengal != Rajasthan != Deccan != Tamil country

DECLINE -> selected older towns, coin streams and political centres contract

CREATION -> new capitals, markets, settlements and literary cultures emerge

VERDICT: transition means reorganisation, not uniform rupture or stasis.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Imperial concentration to regional sovereignty

LARGE IMPERIAL CORE WEAKENS

|

regional dynasties + feudatories + marriage + warfare

|

KING -> SAMANTA -> DISTRICT / LOCALITY -> VILLAGE

|

tribute, military service, grants and negotiated obedience

TENSION: integration can enlarge both royal reach and local landed power.

ASCI MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Land grant: charter to ground effects

ROYAL OR LOCAL CLAIM OVER LAND

|

brahmadeya / agrahara / devadana grant with boundaries and exemptions

|

beneficiary rights + fiscal reassignment + local intermediaries

|

settlement, cultivation, hierarchy and institutional endowment

LIMIT: charter rhetoric proves a claim; implementation needs other evidence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Agrarian frontier and social incorporation

FOREST / PASTORAL / CULTIVATED ZONES

|

irrigation + plough expansion + grants + temples + new settlements

|

chiefs, peasants, Brahmanas, artisans and labour groups negotiate place

|

surplus extraction + ranked rights + new regional political society

CAUTION: incorporation could create mobility and deepen exclusion together.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Indian feudalism debate

R. S. SHARMA -> grants, intermediaries, landlordism and reduced mobility
D. D. KOSAMBI -> change from above and below; social-formation approach
HAR BANS MUKHIA -> warns against mechanical European manor-serf transfer
REGIONAL STUDIES -> chronology, ecology and exchange vary substantially
USEFUL CORE -> ask who controlled land, surplus, labour and armed force
VERDICT: use feudalism as a tested model, not a universal label.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Trade, money and town transformation

CONTRACTION CLAIM

selected coin decline

older urban centres weaken

some long routes contract

merchant visibility changes

SYNTHESIS -> old urban forms decline while new nodes and circuits grow.

TRANSFORMATION CLAIM

monetisation varies by region

new capitals and temple towns emerge

coastal and regional exchange continues

guilds and markets persist unevenly

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Varna text and jati process

VARNA -> normative fourfold vocabulary in prescriptive texts

JATI -> numerous lived, occupational and regional social groups

MOBILITY -> rulers and communities seek ranked identities and genealogies

EXCLUSION -> untouchability and unequal labour become more visible

EVIDENCE -> law text + inscription + donation + settlement + material record

TRAP: a normative text is not a demographic census.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Brahmanisation, localisation, gender and frontier

BRAHMANICAL IDIOMS <-> local cults, chiefs and community practice

GENEALOGY + RITUAL + GRANT -> political legitimisation

LOCAL DEITIES + CUSTOM -> reshape received Sanskrit forms

WOMEN -> queens and donors visible; ordinary labour remains under-recorded

FRONTIER GROUPS -> incorporation, resistance and layered identity

VERDICT: cultural change is multidirectional, unequal and locally remade.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: Religion and temple as institution

TEMPLE

- |-- sacred centre: ritual, bhakti and pilgrimage
- |-- landholder: grants, fields and irrigation rights
- |-- employer: priests, artisans, dancers and service groups
- |-- redistributor: food, gifts, credit and festival expenditure
- `-- archive: inscriptions preserve donors, taxes and local decisions

PLURAL FIELD -> Puranic, Buddhist, Jaina, tantric and local traditions.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Language, knowledge and regional cultures

SANSKRIT COSMOPOLIS -> portable prestige, genealogy and political idiom

|

Tamil, Kannada, Telugu, Bengali and other literary worlds deepen

|

translation + commentary + inscription + devotional performance

|

regional cultures become locally rooted yet interregionally connected

CONTINUITY: Sanskrit does not vanish. CHANGE: vernacular agency expands.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Evidence-led synthesis answer spine

OPEN -> define early medieval as an uneven transition
POLITY -> regional states + samantas + negotiated sovereignty
ECONOMY -> grants + agrarian expansion + transformed exchange and towns
SOCIETY -> jati, mobility, exclusion, gender and frontier incorporation
CULTURE -> temple institutions + bhakti + vernacularisation
DEBATE -> test feudalism against regional evidence
CLOSE -> ancient legacies survive through transformation and reinvention.